consciousness, as I had allowed it to from mine. In today's India, that will no longer do.

The recent official findings confirming the persistence of the iniquitous practice of caste discrimination across India's religious communities do not exonerate Hindu society. But caste, Swami Vivekananda told us, has nothing to do with religion: it is a purely social practice, and many Hindus can and should bring up their children to abhor the idea of caste. In the *Purana*s there is the story of a debate between the *rishis* Vasistha and Vishwamitra on whether the Vedic religion could be universalised or whether it was intended for the Aryan people alone. The *Upanishad*s broadened the appeal of the ritualistic religion depicted in the Vedas, and sages like Adi Shankara and Ramanuja democratised it further. Indeed, Adi Shankara declared that any human being, merely by virtue of their personhood, could attain the Supreme Consciousness through a study of the scriptures, the *Purana*s and the epics, meditation (*japa*), fasting (*upavasa*) and worship (*puja*). Caste was never approved of by Adi Shankara. The contemporary rejection of caste draws from a long reformist tradition in Hinduism that embraces all of them, as well as Kabir, Nanak, Shirdi Sai Baba, Sree Narayana Guru and Mahatma Gandhi.

Hindu society may have maintained a distasteful practice, but no one can credibly argue that it is intrinsic to the religion. There is a marvellous story of Utanga, a childhood friend of Lord Krishna, who had received a boon from Krishna that the Lord would provide him water whenever he needed it on his wanderings. On one occasion, overcome by thirst in a remote place, Utanga called upon his boon. An outcaste hunter soon appeared before him, clad in skins and dirty rags, offering him water from an animal-skin water bag. Utanga, a fastidious Brahmin, turned down his offer. The hunter continued his attempts to persuade him to drink the water but Utanga was haughtily unmoved, berating Lord Krishna in his mind for not having fulfilled his promise. The hunter, his generosity spurned even by a man in need, duly disappeared. Soon Krishna himself materialised before Utanga, informing him that he had sent Indra, the king of the Devas, in the guise of the hunter, to offer him not just water but *amrit*, the nectar of immortality. 'Since, instead of